

Yann Burden

Product and Technology Leader -- Energy, Connected Platforms, Scale-ups

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Summary

Three-time founder/executive who has built, scaled, and exited technology businesses in the energy and customer engagement sectors. Deep domain expertise in residential energy markets (smart metering, retailer analytics, customer behaviour). Track record of turning technical products into connected platform propositions and scaling teams through acquisition. Combines strategic product leadership with commercial acumen and hands-on technical credibility.

Experience

Founder and Advisor | Energy Return | 2024 -- present

Independent advisory practice focused on AI strategy, product development, and go-to-market for technology companies.

- Advising early-stage companies on product strategy and commercial positioning
- Published career context at energyreturn.co

Chief Growth Officer, then Chief AI Officer | Pendula | 2021 -- 2024

Agentic customer engagement platform. Joined as CGO to lead growth, moved to CAO to lead AI and product strategy. Business grew from 40 to 120 people and was acquired by Tally Group.

- **Product and platform leadership:** Owned product roadmap for a connected platform orchestrating customer conversations across SMS, email, voice, and messaging channels
- **Scale-up execution:** Grew the business through Series A (\$14.5M) to acquisition, managing the transition from founder-led sales to structured go-to-market
- **Distributed team leadership:** Led product, data science, and growth teams spanning Sydney and offshore engineering
- **Commercial outcomes:** Drove enterprise pipeline and conversion, translating technical capability into buyer-ready product narratives
- **AI in production:** Shipped agentic workflows -- ML-driven decisioning orchestrating real customer conversations at scale, pre-LLM

Co-founder and CEO | Billcap | 2014 -- 2021

Vertical ML platform for energy retailers. Built personalised customer engagement products using smart meter data at scale. Three energy retailer customers. Business acquired by Pendula.

- **Energy domain expertise:** Deep knowledge of the residential energy market -- retailer economics, customer behaviour, smart metering infrastructure, regulatory environment
- **Connected data platform:** Built and operated a platform ingesting smart meter data and generating personalised insights, driving retention and cross-sell for energy retailers
- **Product-market fit in energy:** Developed product strategy that turned commodity energy relationships into personalised engagement -- the same challenge facing connected home energy products
- **Research credibility:** Work contributed to peer-reviewed publications including the Journal of Political Economy (top-5 economics journal) and the Review of Economics and Statistics. La Nauze (2019) explicitly credits Billcap for data access.
- **IoT-adjacent data infrastructure:** Managed high-volume time-series data pipelines from smart meters -- hardware-generated data processed through ML models to drive customer outcomes

Senior Consultant | Accenture | 2012 -- 2014

Technology consulting for enterprise clients. Delivered large-scale system implementations and business transformation programs.

- Enterprise stakeholder management and cross-functional delivery
- Technology strategy and vendor evaluation

Consultant | PwC | 2009 -- 2012

Management consulting with a focus on strategy, operations, and technology-enabled transformation.

- Business case development and strategic analysis
- Process improvement and operational design

Education

Bachelor of Commerce (Honours) | University of Melbourne First Class Honours in Economics. Thesis on energy market dynamics.

Selected Publications and Media

- "Power from the People" (La Nauze, 2019) -- *Journal of Political Economy* (top-5). Acknowledges Billcap for data access.
- "Tell Me Something I Don't Already Know" (Byrne, Martin et al., 2018) -- *Review of Economics and Statistics* (top-5).
- "An Experimental Study of Monthly Electricity Demand (In)elasticity" (Byrne, Martin et al., 2021) -- *The Energy Journal*.
- Melbourne Uni Pursuit feature -- quoted directly on smart meter data and customer behaviour.
- Domain.com.au energy feature (2017) -- quoted as expert voice on residential energy engagement.
- Tech Trajectory podcast with Kavita Karwar, DiUS (2025) -- on AI-driven customer engagement.

Key Strengths for This Role

- **Energy domain depth:** A decade in residential energy, from smart meter data to retailer strategy to customer behaviour research
- **Connected platform experience:** Built and scaled platforms where the value was in the ecosystem, not the individual product
- **Scale-up track record:** Three exits, including navigating the 40-to-120 person growth phase and M&A integration
- **Product strategy and commercial alignment:** Product decisions that drive revenue, not roadmaps that drive features
- **Distributed team leadership:** Experience managing product and engineering across Sydney and offshore teams